STATE OF THE STATE CONCLAVE ODISHA 2022

and 81 for the most improved districts, which was backed by expert inputs from academia, policymakers and policy influencers.

Odisha is now not just the fastest growing state in the country but is also aiming at a Rs 6 trillion economy in the not so distant future. And this looks possible because of a politically stable and consistent government, robust infrastructure, market-oriented policies and availability of rich natural resources. Value addition on raw natural resources has led to a 300 per cent increase in mining revenues. The consistent development of human resources through skill development and upgradation has enhanced the employability of youth, who constitute 50 per cent of the state population.

Enhancing skills for a total human transformation is what the Odisha Skill Development Authority strives for. It now has a high-tech World Skill Center to hone vocational skills. Odisha today contributes around 11 per cent of the country's skilled workforce. By setting up model degree colleges in backward areas and government-run English medium schools in each block, Odisha is now aiming to bridge the demographic divide as well.

In terms of law and order and women's empowerment, Odisha got accolades from Ambika Satapathy, founder of start-up ZooFresh Foods. Needless to say, many of the start-ups in Odisha have women founders. The Patnaik government's focus on women through Mission Shakti is well known and now efforts are on to upgrade the skills of more and more of them so that they can ride the growth wave of the state.

Of course, despite all the positivity, Odisha is far from being the finished article. The numbers with Niti Aayog suggest that 30 per cent of the people are still in the BPL category, 60 per cent do not have access to clean fuel and sanitation levels are bad in many places. The irony is that the state's richest districts in terms of mineral resources are also the poorest in terms of poverty. Keonjhar contributes 21 per cent to the country's pool of minerals but poverty is a high 62 per cent. In terms of providing safe drinking water to the urban poor, Odisha has drawn up an ambitious



(From L) **Dr Omkar Rai,** *Chairman, O-Hub;* **Debiprasad Sarangi,** *CEO, IserveU Technology Pvt Ltd;* **Binayak Acharya,** *Founder, ThinkZone;* **Ambika Satapathy,** *Founder, Zoofresh Foods*

▲ BHUBANESWAR AS A START-UP DESTINATION: ACHIEVEMENTS AND CHALLENGES

TAKEAWAYS

1. The Odisha government launched the 'O-hub' start-up programme in December 2021 and aims to facilitate 5,000 start-ups by 2025
2. Women show the way in Odisha. Of the total start-ups, a substantial section is led by women
3. The state has good infrastructure and law and order to support the growth of start-ups
4. Odisha is ahead of many states in implementation of policies, clearance time for projects and availability of talent—the state produces 900,000 graduates every year
5. The state is working towards providing access to capital for start-ups to scale up. This includes tapping the Odia diaspora across the world



Hemant Sharma, *Principal secretary, industries department, Odisha;* **Ranjan Nayak,** *COO, JSW Utkal Steel;* **Rajib Sekhar Sahoo,** *Economist;* **Sachin R. Jadhav,** *Director, Odisha Tourism*